

Elephants

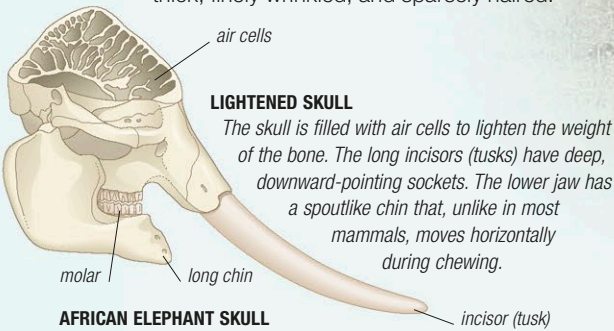
PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Proboscidea
FAMILIES	1 (Elephantidae)
SPECIES	3

The largest living animals on land—the male African savanna elephant may be as tall as 13 ft (4 m) and weigh nearly 11 tons (10 tonnes)—elephants are characterized by pillarlike legs, a thick-set body with a convexly curved spine, large ears (relatively smaller in Asian elephants), and a heavy head with a long,

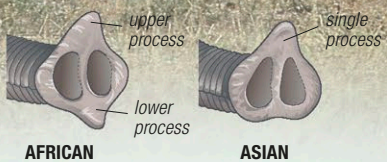
mobile trunk. African and Asian elephants live in savanna and lightht forest; African forest elephants (recently given species status) mainly live deep in the African rain forest (they occasionally venture on to the savanna). Elephants live for about 65–70 years—longer than any other mammals except humans. Previously, elephants were thought to grow throughout their lives, but this is not considered true today.

Anatomy

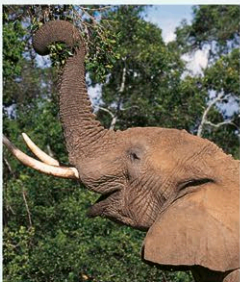
Perhaps the most distinctive feature is the trunk, a flexible elongation of the upper lip and nose that consists of thousands of muscle fibers. It is used like a “5th limb” to pluck grass, pull down branches, lift logs, or squirt water or dust. Also immediately noticeable are the tusks (upper incisors), which are large, thick, and curved in most bull elephants; cows have smaller tusks (in female Asian elephants they do not protrude beyond the lip). Their tusks are known to grow throughout life. The skeleton consists of thick, heavy bones, which are able to support the animal’s great weight. The large, fan-shaped ears, which contain a network of blood vessels, are constantly in motion to aid heat loss. In aggressive displays, the ears are spread sideways. The skin is thick, finely wrinkled, and sparsely haired.



DIGGING FOR SALT
Elephants often need to supplement their diet with extra salt. This juvenile African elephant is loosening fragments of salt-rich soil with its tusks. Juveniles learn from older members of the herd where to find salt.



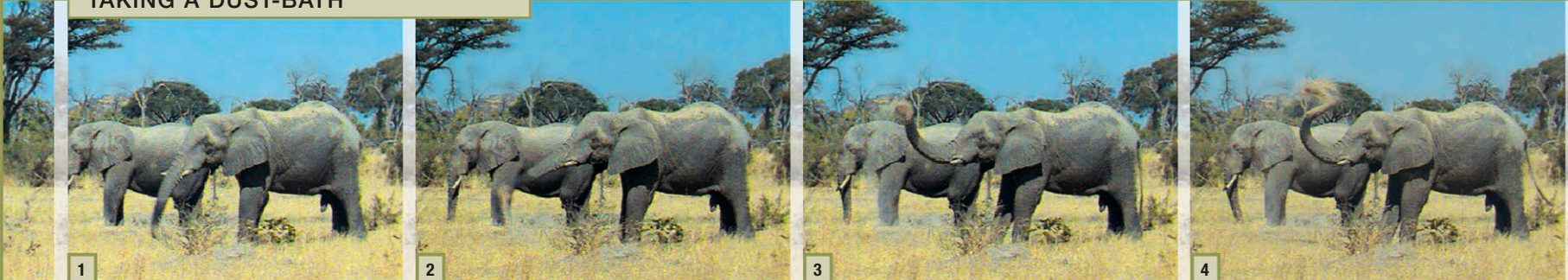
TRUNK SHAPE
African elephants have 2 opposing, fingerlike outgrowths called processes at the tip of the trunk; Asian elephants have one. In both, the processes are used to pick up small objects.



STRIPPING FOLIAGE
Elephants use their mobile trunk to pull down branches. An adult needs to eat about 350 lb (160 kg) of food daily.



TAKING A DUST-BATH



DAILY ROUTINE
To keep the skin healthy, African elephants take a daily dust-bath.

SUCKING UP THE DUST
Dust is sucked up into the trunk, which is a tubular extension of the upper lip.

PROTECTION
The dust acts as a sunscreen, protecting the elephant’s skin from the direct rays of the sun.

REPELLING INSECTS
Dust is also a good insect repellent, deterring insects from biting the sensitive skin.